of the way the US executed the war. Viewing 9/11 as a ghastly, but also an enlightening moment for the US, India expected empathy from Washington on the issue of cross-border terrorism. America's partnering with Pakistan as a frontline state, with the hope that Islamabad would curb expressions of terrorism against the US and its allies, especially India, was a disappointment for New Delhi. Indeed, top US officials including secretary of defense Donald Rumsfeld knew that many Pakistani officials (despite Musharraf's tilt) were retaining ties with the Taliban and various other militant groups operating against India.[90]

In a joint parliamentary session on the international situation arising out of the 9/11 attacks, there was agreement on the benefits of ousting the Taliban, as well as India's proactive measures to increase engagement with Afghanistan's upcoming political dispensation. On the economic front, despite concerns of a global economic downturn, no particular negative economic fallout was expected given the minuscule levels of trade between Afghanistan and India. With its global exports growing at 1.95 per cent and imports at 1.81 per cent, the Ministries of Finance and Commerce and Industry were happy that the sluggish global energy demand had reduced oil prices.[91] A dip from US$ 28 per barrel on 11 September 2001 to US$ 20 per barrel on 20 November had relieved pressure on India's balance of payments. Even the INR per US$ appreciated 0.3 per cent in this time frame, and the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) assured the domestic Indian market that adequate foreign exchange would be provided if the supply-demand gap increased due to the war. The question of whether India should support the US or not lingered, however, as disagreements emerged in three different aspects: (a) Washington's acceptance of Pakistan as a frontline state in the war against terror and the myth of the Taliban's disintegration, (b) undermining of international institutions such as the UN (whose official sanction came in December 2001, even though it was clear from the outset that the UN would approve such military action), and (c) the need for Vajpayee's 'complaint letter' to Bush after the J&K assembly attack. The Leader of the Opposition, Dr Manmohan Singh, who became PM in 2004, with support from the communists and regional parties such as the Samajwadi Party (SP), led the charge against the NDA government's position on these issues.